SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #27 · APPEARANCE AND BODY IMAGE

"I'm ugly, and nothing can change that."

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Where it often comes from

Words spoken in childhood, teasing, comparisons, or photographs can fasten the label "ugly" to a person for life. Mirrors then confirm what we expect to see, and we may avoid photos, intimacy, or mirrors altogether. Sometimes there is also a real condition, scar, or difference that draws unkind attention.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, "You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well." Scripture says, "God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good." The Bridegroom says to the beloved, "You are altogether beautiful, my darling." Jesus Himself "had no stately form or majesty to attract us, no beauty that we should desire Him," and He was and is loved by the Father. Beauty in God's eyes is not decided by culture's standard.

> *"For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well"* (Psalm 139:13–14).

Also see

> "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day" (Genesis 1:31).

> "You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw" (Song of Solomon 4:7).

> "He grew up before Him like a tender shoot, and like a root out of dry ground. He had no stately form or majesty to attract us, no beauty that we should desire Him" (Isaiah 53:2).

> "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows" (Luke 12:7).

Common self-statements

- I am hideous.
- I always look wrong.
- No one could find me attractive.
- I cannot stand to see myself.
- Nothing will help.
- Everyone sees my flaws first.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Calling myself ugly.
- Magnification: Focusing on perceived flaws.
- Mind reading: Assuming others see me as unattractive.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will change.

Challenging questions

- Who first called me ugly, and what was going on with them?
- Do I see my friends' flaws as I see my own?
- What do others who love me notice about me?
- What does God say He made?
- What parts of my body am I grateful for?
- What would change if I treated my reflection as I would a friend's?

Truth summary

> God made me and called what He made good. I may have been hurt by words, but they do not decide my beauty or worth. I can learn to see myself with gentler eyes and receive that I am fearfully and wonderfully made.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, Creator
- Gifts, Physical/Material
- Love, By God
- Thinking, Unhealthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm ugly, and nothing can change that"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm ugly, and nothing can change that." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who first said this?
- ☐ How do I see my friends?
- ☐ What do loved ones notice?
- ☐ What did God make?
- ☐ What am I grateful for?
- ☐ What gentle thing can I say?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ God called His creation good.
- ☐ Beauty is more than culture's standard.
- ☐ Words from the past do not decide the truth.
- ☐ I can see myself with kindness.
- ☐ Jesus was loved without worldly beauty.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 139:13–14**
  "For You formed my inmost being; You knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Genesis 1:31**
  "And God looked upon all that He had made, and indeed, it was very good. And there was evening, and there was morning—the sixth day."
- ☐ **Song of Solomon 4:7**
  "You are altogether beautiful, my darling; in you there is no flaw."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Gentle eyes: Each day, say one kind and true thing about your body or yourself.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 139:13–14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am fearfully and wonderfully made.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the source. Write who first said it and what they might have been feeling.
- [ ] Practice gratitude. Thank God for one thing your body does each day.
- [ ] Say one kind thing in the mirror. Start small.
- [ ] Seek help if it is consuming. If thoughts about appearance take over your life, talk to a counselor.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm ugly, and nothing can change that": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Gentle eyes
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm ugly, and nothing can change that.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Creator, You knit me together and called me good. Heal the words spoken over me. Teach me to see myself with gentleness and gratitude. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.